



Japan, New Zealand book their tickets

After a hard-fought 2-0 win over Bahrain in the third round of AFC qualifiers for next year's marquee event in the United States, Canada, and Mexico, Japan became the first side to qualify for the 2026 FIFA World Cup after the host nations.

This is the eighth consecutive time that the Asian side has qualified for the quadrennial tournament, reiterating the juggernaut that it is in the continent.

The Samurai Blue's best finish at the World Cup remains multiple Round of 16 appearances. The most recent one, in Qatar in 2022, showed that Japan can go toe-to-toe against European powerhouses after it beat the likes of Germany and Spain in the group stage.

While Japan confirmed its berth in

next year's finals with a win in Saitama, almost 9,000 km away and a few days later in Auckland, the island country of New Caledonia harboured dreams of making it to the World Cup for the first time.

The side was holding favourite New Zealand 0-0 in the OFC qualifiers final until the 60th minute. Unfortunately for New Caledonia, 36-year-old Michael Boxall found the net a minute later — his first-ever international goal — to open the floodgates.

Two more goals later, New Zealand followed Japan and became the second team to book its ticket for next year's edition, which is set to have 48 teams.

Mexico wins big

Mauricio Pochettino had a CONCACAF Nations League campaign

to forget as the USA succumbed to a shock 1-0 defeat against underdogs Panama in the semifinal.

Cecilio Waterman scored in the fourth minute of stoppage time to quash the Americans' hopes of winning their fourth consecutive title.

Things went from bad to worse for Pochettino as his side lost 1-2 against Canada in the third-place match, sparking concerns about the team's quality ahead of the FIFA World Cup next year.

Despite the famous win, Panama's dream of lifting the title came to an end after it fell to a 1-2 loss against Mexico in the final.

Veteran Raul Jimenez scored in the eighth minute and converted from the spot in stoppage time to lead Mexico to CONCACAF glory (above).

(All results are updated as of March 24)